Where The Deer and the Buffalo Roam

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55325146.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra)

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by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Kyle and Rogelio left Camp Horde for the Lord one night, determined to be together. Their friend Lonnie picked them up and for a time, things were good. They had a band, Kyle and Rogelio were together, and it seemed like it'd last forever. Then it all fell apart. Finally, they were given a chance to get the band back together for one show and on the way back, they're being reminded of why they broke up as they settle down for a night at a campground. What will come of all of this? Will they make it through or was it simply life?

An In-Between for the Camp Bright Moon series.

The First Night

Chapter Summary

Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie drive into a campsite, not sure what is ahead for them.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Rogelio wasn't much of a talker, never had been, but he hadn't said a word in seven hours as he drove the old minivan through the mountains. Kyle and Lonnie had been griping on and off during that seven hours but neither had said a word to the other in about an hour. The radio was currently set on some country and western station, put there by Lonnie out of spite two hours before, and that no one was willing to change for some reason as it cut in and out with static. As they passed a sign that said Sage Brush Flats Campground, they heard the DJ say, "Alright everyone, it's time to go way back. This one is for all of you out there traveling way out there."

Way Out There by Sons of the Pioneers started up, the yodeling suddenly coming through sharp and clear as the radio caught a good signal for a moment before it went into the opening verse.

"A lonely spot I know where no man will go, Where the shadows have all the room…"

“No, absolutely not,” Kyle said as he finally reached over from the passenger seat and shut it off.

“What’s wrong?” Lonnie said. “We’ve been listening to that for two hours. Don’t you like country and western?”

Kyle turned to where she was sprawled out on the middle bench seat behind him as he said, “No, and you don’t either.”

“Could have fooled me,” Lonnie said as Rogelio rolled his eyes as he turned his attention to the narrow road in the failing light of day. “I mean, you could have changed it at any time.”

“So could you,” Kyle said.

“Just figured I’d let you do what you wanted,” Lonnie said.

“Are we really going to get into this again?” Kyle said as he heard the engine make a little weird squealing noise for a second before the noise stopped just as sudden as it started.

“Get into what?” Lonnie said. “I’m just saying I was letting you have it your way.”

Kyle's lips went thin as he turned back around. Any other time, he'd have been thrilled by the looming mountains on his right, the sprawling high prairie on his left, and the big sand dunes that loomed up to their left. Now he was just tired of arguing. The three of them had tried to have a band after they'd all left Camp Horde for the Lord years before. It'd last for a few years, even been mildly successful in a regional kind of way, but then it'd fallen apart, mostly from bickering like what they'd just been doing. Kyle and Rogelio had been a couple during that time and it fell apart just like the band had. They'd tried to be a couple again a couple of times but it'd never lasted. None of them had seen each other in a little over a year when Kyle had got a call from Lonnie, telling him someone was offering decent money if they'd come and play a show in rural Utah. Against his judgment, he'd agreed. They'd driven for several days to the show in Rogelio's minivan, performed, and had a great night. It'd almost been like it had been back in the good days. Then they'd started driving back.

The first day they hadn't got far, doing sightseeing, and that was when they'd started snipping at each other. The second day hadn't been any better. Then the third day, the day they were on, had started ugly and gone downhill from there. Now Rogelio pulled up to the entry booth for the campground and found that no one was there.

"Is this even open? I mean, it's barely fall, it should be," Kyle said. Rogelio just shrugged as he read the various signs on the small building before pulling forward.

The campground itself looked pretty much deserted. There were a few stone walls along the road with steps leading up to campsites, scrubby pine and fir trees, tons of sagebrush, and sand and rocks

everywhere. The Sun sat behind the high dunes as Rogelio pulled into a campsite close to the bathrooms.

“Are we sure we can camp here?” Kyle said.

“Jesus, yes!” Lonnie said as she slid the door open. “If we couldn't, they'd have the gate closed! It’s just the middle of the damn week, no one’s here!”

“I just don’t want to get in trouble!” Kyle said as he got out. Rogelio shut the engine off with a sigh and immediately went towards the restrooms.

“You going to help!?” Lonnie hollered after him and Rogelio made a noncommittal hand gesture before going in the door.

“He’ll be back,” Kyle said. “He hasn’t used the restroom all day. Barely got out of the car.”

“I know, I was there,” Lonnie said. “Just help me get the food in the bear box.”

“All one bag and one ice chest of it?” Kyle said.

Lonnie flipped him off as she opened the back of the van and said, “Just grab one side of it.”

Lonnie grabbed the bag and then they both got ahold of the ice chest and carried it over to the steel bear box next to the picnic table and fire ring. Signs on the front of the waist high box advised campers to be sure that all food was packed up inside the box and not to feed the wildlife or to leave any food laying about. A secure trash can sat next to the bear box with another sign on it advising all waste to be thrown in it and not to litter. A magpie sat on the ground on the edge of the campsite and chattered a little before flying off as Lonnie got the ice chest into the bear box and closed it up.

Kyle went and grabbed their tent out of the back of the van. At least they called it a tent. All three of them were fairly broke and while they had picked up some cash from the show, they’d been cheap and bought a couple of tarps to use as a tent. Kyle tossed the rolled up tarps on the ground and started unfolding them, setting the stakes and rope off to the side as he did.

Lonnie stood staring at him for a long minute before she shook her head and started walking around the immediate area, alternating between watching the bushes and mountains disappearing in the fading light. She stopped as she watched the snowcaps on the looming mountains turn from white to beautiful rosy colors in the light of the setting Sun.

“Kyle,” Lonnie said, not taking her eyes from the peaks.

“I don’t need your criticism,” Kyle said, not looking up as he drove a stake in.

“Look,” Lonnie said and the tone of her voice caused him to turn.

Kyle’s mouth came open a little bit as he saw the mountains lit up and the complaint he was about to voice dropped from his lips unheard. Rogelio had arrived unseen to the camp and he sat down on the picnic table as they watched the colors drain from the snowcaps as the stars appeared.

“That was beautiful,” Rogelio said.

Lonnie and Kyle both turned to look at Rogelio in the dim light left coming from the sky as Lonnie said, “You do know how to speak.”

Rogelio just shrugged as Kyle said, “Could I get some light over here? I didn’t think about setting up in the dark.”

“Yeah, sorry, I’ll get a flashlight,” Lonnie said as she went to rummage in the back of the van. She was over in a moment holding it while Rogelio helped Kyle get the tarps set up. Once one tarp was up as a roof and the other was rolled out on the ground as a floor, the three got their rolled up blankets and pillows out of the back and threw them inside the shelter.

“I’ll cook something,” Kyle said as he went back to the van and pulled out their one pot.

“Let me guess, beans?” Lonnie said with a sigh.

“I can cook some of the breakfast stuff if you want,” Kyle said as he got a small bag of charcoal and walked over to the raised grill by the picnic table.

“Do the Dinty Moore,” Rogelio said and Kyle lit up.

“Oh, yeah! I forgot we still had that! We can do the last of the rice with it!” he replied.

Lonnie frowned but finally said, “It’s better than beans at least.”

Kyle smiled as he set the stuff down on the picnic table. Rogelio went and got a small battery operated lantern out of the van and set it on the table. Kyle hummed to himself as he set up a small pile of charcoal briquettes and then rummaged in his pockets for a lighter. A couple of clicks later and the coals were starting to burn as Kyle lowered the grate and went to get into the bear box to grab the stew out of the bag as well as some minute rice.

Time seemed to slip slowly by while Kyle made dinner. The stars coming out in the moonless sky were sharp points in the high altitude air. A bright carpet seemed to be laid out to the south of

them in the sky and Kyle let out a long satisfied sigh as he said, "I don't think I've ever seen it that clearly."

"Seen what?" Rogelio asked.

"The Milky Way," Kyle said as he gave the pot a little stir.

"It's unreal how many stars I can see," Lonnie replied. "Can you identify any?"

Kyle grinned as he said, "Can I identify any of them? Remember, I ran the astronomy program at Camp Horde for the Lord!"

"For half a summer," Lonnie said. "Before someone complained about it."

Kyle frowned as he remembered getting called into the camp director's office and getting a talking to about the pagan legends he'd supposedly been teaching and how Camp Horde for the Lord was supposed to be teaching good Christian values. All he'd done was tell the Greek stories from the constellations but he reminded himself that was in the past as he said, "Yeah, their loss."

"It was," Rogelio replied as he stretched.

“Well, you going to point some out or not?” Lonnie said.

Kyle frowned for a moment as he looked around.

“Um, I’m not used to seeing this many. It’s actually kind of hard to pick stuff out but I think that’s Sagitarrius there,” he said as he pointed to the south. “I think that the really bright one really low in the south is Antares. It’s part of Scorpio but it’s hard to tell since I think the rest is below the horizon. Over there in the southeast I think is Saturn coming up over that peak. I’m guessing on that one, I’d need an up to date chart to know for sure. That square off to the west is Hercules… well, I’m pretty sure it is. Seriously, it’s hard to tell with all of these stars!”

“Guess it’s a good problem to have,” Lonnie said.

“Dinner ready?” Rogelio asked.

“I guess?” Kyle said, looking down. He couldn’t really see in the pot in the dark but it didn’t look like it was bubbling like he’d expect. “It’s not really bubbling.”

“Taste it,” Lonnie said.

Kyle did and while it was warm, it wasn’t really getting hot.

“I don’t know what’s wrong,” he said. “It should be enough coals.”

“Maybe it’s the altitude,” Rogelio said with a shrug.

“Maybe,” Kyle said before looking around at the brush and trees. “And this is all pine, it won’t really help a fire.”

“You said it was warm at least?” Lonnie said. Kyle said yes and she went on. “Then screw it, I don’t care, I’m starving. Bring it over.”

Rogelio just shrugged and Kyle picked the pot off the grill and brought it over to the table. Rogelio grabbed the last of their sodas out of the cooler and a couple of spoons and they were soon all digging in at the pot.

“We just want to drive straight through tomorrow to home?” Lonnie said.

“That’s a pretty long drive,” Rogelio said.

“Yeah, but let’s be honest, we’re all getting pretty sick of each other I think,” Lonnie replied.

“Hey, that’s not true,” Kyle said.

“Is that why we didn’t talk for like two hours and you listened to that fucking awful radio channel for so long?” Lonnie said.

“I just was giving you space,” Kyle said.

“How did that radio channel last so long?” Rogelio said. “Figured it was going to fade out pretty quick but it kept going.”

“Because it was cursed,” Lonnie replied.

“Come on, though, are we really going to do a big drive tomorrow?” Kyle said.

“Well, where else do you want to stop?” Lonnie said, her tone aggressive. “Between here and home it’s almost all high prairie for the most part. We’ll be out of the mountains in a couple of hours and then what? Want to sample the charms of panhandle country? See some really flat plains? And it’s not like we have a ton of food left. I think we’re done here.”

“Could we just stay here?” Kyle said. “Maybe one more night?”

“Why? What’s the point? It’s the same as when the band broke up. We get on each other’s nerves,” Lonnie said. “I mean, why did you and Rogelio break up?”

“We’re not talking about that,” Rogelio said.

“We just did, alright?” Kyle said.

“Fine, we’re not going to talk about that, we’ve barely managed to go an hour without getting into an argument over the last couple of days, so what, you want to spend more time out here isolated so we can scream at each other and burn the place down in our rage?” Lonnie said.

“I just miss hanging out with you guys,” Kyle said.

“Yeah, well, we’ve been doing that for days now,” Lonnie said. “I’m just about done.” With that, Lonnie tossed her spoon in the pot. “Yeah, I’m done. You all have the rest.”

She stood up and stalked off down the road.

“Take a flashlight,” Rogelio called after her but they could just barely see her flip them both off. Rogelio sighed and fumbled around inside his coat before he pulled out a pack of cigarettes and lit one up.

“I thought you quit,” Kyle said.

Rogelio just responded with a grunt and a shrug.

Kyle looked down at what was left of the stew. He wasn't really hungry anymore but he'd been taught, rather forcefully, early in life not to waste food so he took a deep sigh and finished up the last bit before going over to the water faucet by the bathroom and filling the pot. He walked back over and put it on the fire, trying to ignore the smell of the cigarette that wafted past him.

"It's not going to boil with just those few coals," Rogelio said.

"Is there anything else you want to criticize tonight!?" Kyle snapped at him.

"Sorry," Rogelio said, holding his hands up.

"No, don't, don't you do that like you always do," Kyle said.

"What?" Rogelio said.

"Acting like I've lashed out at you," Kyle said. "And you're just trying to be the mellow dude."

“You did lash out. I was just pointing out the lack of heat,” Rogelio said.

“You know what, you do it then,” Kyle said as he walked towards the shelter. “I cooked it, you clean it.”

“Fine,” Rogelio said as Kyle crawled under the tarp.

Rogelio took a long drag on the cigarette as he looked up into the star studded sky. He could see a faint glow in the east that outlined the mountain peaks and he assumed it was the Moon starting to make an appearance. He got up and tossed the cigarette butt into the coals of the fire and then gathered up a few pine twigs by the light of the lantern and fed them to the fire. They flared up, the smell of pinion pine strong as the smoke drifted past his face. He fed a few more to the fire as the first few burned down and managed to get the water hot enough to at least simmer a little. Using some hand soap, he washed the pot and spoons and then made sure to dump everything on the other side of the restrooms before storing it all in the bear box.

Rogelio put the lantern on the ground and lay down on the table as he stared up into the night sky. He hated that the three of them argued all the time. Lonnie had been a friend of his since he was a little kid and he’d introduced her to Kyle the year before she’d picked up the two of them when they’d both run away from Camp Horde for the Lord. As to Kyle, he’d loved Kyle for years. Even when he didn’t understand what he was feeling, Kyle had been the closest to him. He remembered when Kyle and Adora had dated and how angry he’d been about it even though absolutely nothing had come of it.

He remembered when he'd been sitting as a lifeguard at the pool when he'd finally admitted how he felt to himself. It'd been at the end of the summer and it'd taken him until the beginning of the next summer to tell Kyle how he felt. He'd hated sneaking around but then finally, they'd run away from camp together, accidentally picking the same night that Catra and Adora had, and it'd been great. They'd crashed at Lonnie's apartment, they'd been a couple, they'd loved each other and they'd started a band. Everything had been great, at least until it wasn't.

Coming out to their families had been one big stress for Rogelio and Kyle. For Rogelio, he'd got insults from his uncles, partial understanding from his mother and aunts, confusion but acceptance from his father which had actually been surprising, and then things had chilled out. Kyle's mother had completely ignored it and tried to pretend like it hadn't happened. Kyle's father had called him every homophobic slur he could think of and then tried to get Rogelio to fight him as the two of them stood in the living room holding each other's hands for support.

Rogelio had always thought that's where it had started the downward spiral for their relationship. He wasn't sure why, he'd done his best to be there for Kyle but it had. They'd spent a lot of time crammed into small vehicles as they'd traveled for the band and when they weren't traveling, they shared a one room apartment with Lonnie and a revolving string of one or two other people, some of them being Lonnie's friends or partners and some of them being Kyle or Rogelio's friends or acquaintances. It felt like they had never had any room to themselves, any place they could just sit and be in silence or even get away from the other for a while. With all of that had come the suffering Kyle was very obviously in with his parents harassing him about his choices one second and then ignoring him the next.

It’d all fallen apart in arguments and ugliness.

Rogelio grunted as he got off the table and went over to the van. His guitar was sitting there in the back and he went back to the table with it. He was pretty sure Kyle was still awake, but as he tuned the guitar for a moment, he didn’t particularly care. He turned the lantern off and played to the Moon as it came up over the mountains. It wasn’t any particular song, he just let his fingers wander on the strings and the strings told a quiet and melancholy song. He found himself humming along with it as the Moon slowly slipped higher and somewhere out in the brush a few coyotes howled up at it.

Rogelio let the notes trail off with no real ending and as he did, he realized that Lonnie was standing by the van in the darkness.

“That was pretty good,” she said as she walked over to the picnic table.

“Thanks,” Rogelio said as he absently ran a nail down a string and listened to the quiet screech.

“It’s how I found camp,” Lonnie said. “Didn’t think you turned the lantern off.”

“Sorry, wasn’t thinking,” Rogelio said. “Just wanted some dark.”

“I’ll forgive you for a smoke,” Lonnie said. Rogelio handed the pack and lighter over to her and she lit and took a deep draw before blowing the smoke towards the stars. “Kyle already go to bed?”

“He got mad at me,” Rogelio said.

“Kind of the story of us you know,” Lonnie said as Rogelio took the pack and lighter back from her and lit up himself.

“Yeah, I know,” Rogelio replied.

They both smoked in quiet for a few minutes until they heard a rustling noise. They turned and in the light of the partial Moon, saw Kyle crawling out from under the tarp. No one said anything as he walked over and picked up the pack of cigarettes sitting next to Rogelio and tapped one out.

“You don’t smoke,” Rogelio said.

“Maybe I want to start,” Kyle said as he lit the cigarette, the flame from the lighter bright in the darkness before going out.

“This should be amusing,” Lonnie said and it wasn’t more than a few seconds later that Kyle started coughing. “Enjoying that?”

“Shut up,” Kyle muttered as he sat down on the table next to Rogelio. He took another drag, slower and more careful this time, and then blew the smoke out. Rogelio gave him a little bump with his shoulder and in the dim moonlight, Kyle could see him grinning at him. “It’s fine, I like it.”

Kyle coughed a few more times as he smoked but otherwise they just listened to the coyotes’ howls and barks. As they finished up Kyle spoke quietly as he said, “Sounds like the coyotes back at camp.”

“I mean, they’re coyotes,” Lonnie said. “Do they sound different?”

“Yeah, I know,” Kyle said. “Just saying.”

A long drawn out howl sounded to be answered by another in a different direction.

“Reminds me of my first time camping out with my mom,” Lonnie said. “It was at a lake by our town. Totally not wild but Mom wanted to let me try camping. Bought a cheap tent, drove out there in her old car, cooked hot dogs over a fire, and then I spent half the night wide awake because I thought wolves were nearby. Mom finally told me it was someone’s yappy dog that lived near the lake and to go to sleep. Soon as she said it, I could hear the difference. She always had that power, to be able to put things in perspective like that.”

“I remember,” Rogelio said.

“She sounds like a good mom,” Kyle said.

Lonnie took one last drag on the cigarette before stubbing it out on the table.

“Yeah, she was,” Lonnie said, suddenly brusque. “What it is. Let’s get to sleep, long drive tomorrow.”

Kyle started to say something but finally just deflated as he stubbed out his cigarette as well.

“Alright.”

Chapter End Notes

Welcome back to Camp Bright Moon AU! This is one I've wanted to do for *awhile*. I briefly referenced it in Graduation and I'm looking forward to showing these three's lost weekend.

This fic marks the first time I have EVER had Rogelio speak. Well, I should say it’s the first time I’ve ever had him speak in words we understand. I always stuck with the show’s convention that he isn’t speaking Etherian (or whatever you’d call it) and when I wrote him in the Camp Bright Moon AU, I never had him speak there either. Why? Because. That’s the best I could say. But I knew if I was going to do a fic with

these three together, I couldn't have it just be Lonnie and Kyle talking and Rogelio staying silent, it just wouldn't work. So, because of that, Rogelio speaks!

The campground in question is loosely based on the Pinon Flats Campground at the Great Sand Dunes National Park and Reserve in Colorado. I did not name it that because I wanted to play around with details a little but it'll give you an idea of what the place looks like (and the park is awesome if you ever get a chance to go).

The tarp thing is something I did when I was broke and wanted to go camping. A tent could cost $30 or $40 and not really be a good tent and be cramped as well. You can get a 9'x12' tarp for about $8. Get two and you got a floor covering as well. Toss in some cheap rope and a little know how and you got yourself a pretty roomy sleeping area. Of course, you gotta be a bit more comfortable with the whole outdoors thing because you're more exposed because it's not enclosed like a tent but if you're on a budget, you can't beat it. The blanket rolls are something I've done as well. I guess what I'm trying to say is that you can go camping for really cheap if you've got the willingness to just repurpose some stuff.

For those who might not know, Dinty Moore is a cheap brand of canned beef stew and something I used to love when I was a teenager doing camp outs. It's, um, not that great and loaded with salt so I don't eat it anymore but it does lend itself as a solid base for adding in a few things like rice or other stew ingredients.

Anyway, thank you for reading and I hope you enjoy this one!

The Second Night

Chapter Summary

> The plans to go home are unraveling and now the trio are stuck in the campground.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As the Sun headed towards the horizon in the west again, a Jeep pulled up behind Rogelio's minivan. Rogelio jumped out of the Jeep with some plastic bags in his hand, said a few words to the driver, and then started walking back over to where Kyle and Lonnie were both sitting on opposite sides of the campsite.

"Well, where's the parts?" Lonnie said as she looked at what were obviously grocery bags.

"They'll be here in two days," Rogelio said.

"What!?" Lonnie replied. "You said it just needed a belt!"

"It does. For an old minivan. Two days," Rogelio said as he sat down on the bench with a sigh and put the bags on the table.

“Can we just make one or use the old one!?” Lonnie said. Rogelio’s look answered her as she threw her hands up in the air. “We’re really stuck here!?”

“Yep,” Rogelio said. “I got some more food though and paid for the part so now we just have to wait.”

“I assume you used the band money?” Lonnie said.

“Yeah,” Rogelio said.

“That was supposed to be split up when we were done!” Lonnie said.

“And we won’t get anywhere to split it up if he doesn’t spend it so how about you lay off him?” Kyle said.

“Oh, look, you speak finally,” Lonnie said.

“Because you’ve been a dick all day!” Kyle said.

Rogelio sighed again as he remembered starting the minivan up in the morning. He’d heard a little squealing noise and then, as he’d put the car in reverse, it’d turned into a loud squealing noise followed by a thumping noise in the engine compartment. He’d

immediately shut the car off as both Lonnie and Kyle shouted out asking what had happened as he got under the hood and immediately saw what he'd feared.

"Serpentine belt," Rogelio said as he looked at the tangled belt. He reached down and started moving parts until he found what he feared. "Think the A/C compressor seized and threw the belt."

"OK, and?" Lonnie said.

"And I need to get a new belt. It really needs a new compressor too but I can bypass it. We won't have A/C though," Rogelio said.

"It's freezing right now," Kyle said. "I doubt it'll be too bad even when we're out of the mountains."

"My thoughts too," Rogelio said. "I'll hike out and see if I can get a ride into town."

And without waiting to see what the other said, he'd done just that. Kyle and Lonnie had tried to amuse themselves but after a while, it'd just turned to them arguing and one or the other walking away. Kyle had ended up down at a small creek that ran between the where the sage brush and pines started and the dunes ended. The water was clear and low, the little ripples of the water reflecting the rippled sand that it ran over. He'd spent as much time as he could there, walking back and forth and poking his toe into the cold water once before heading back.

When he'd got back, Lonnie had been sitting on the table, nibbling at the last of the bread and bacon they'd had. She'd silently handed him half the sandwich and he'd eaten it sitting next to her as they watched birds flit in and out of the brush. After Kyle finished the sandwich he sat for a long moment, trying to think of what he was going to say before finally just saying it.

"Why do you hate me now?"

"I don't hate you."

"It sure seems like it sometimes."

"Listen, I don't want to talk about this, alright? Just go back to whatever it was you were doing."

"I'm trying to fix something here. I hate that we don't talk anymore."

Lonnie looked away from the little brown bird she was watching to look at Kyle.

"Kyle, I don't know what happened. It just got fucked up and that's that," Lonnie said. "I wouldn't even be on this trip if I didn't need some cash."

“Is that why you wanted to get home?” Kyle asked.

“Kinda but mostly I wasn’t kidding, I’m sick of being around you both,” Lonnie said.

“Don’t be a dick,” Kyle said.

“Hey, I told you I didn’t want to talk,” Lonnie said. “You just had to keep asking.”

“Because I was trying to… you know what, screw it,” Kyle said as he jumped off the table and started walking off. “Just be unhappy, I don’t care anymore.”

Kyle came back later to find Lonnie sitting on the bench, studiously ignoring him and he returned the favor for several hours until Rogelio came back. Now Kyle was going through the food that Rogelio had brought as Lonnie shook her head and said, “I can’t believe this. I really can’t. How long are we going to be stuck here?”

“I said two days,” Rogelio said. “I even got the parts guy to agree to send it to the park office here so I just got to go and pick it up. It could be worse.”

“It could be a hell of a lot better,” Lonnie said before seeming to deflate. “I just want to go home.”

“You and me both,” Kyle grumbled as he carried the food to the bear box.

Rogelio sat down on the table as he said, “It’s not so bad. The aspens are pretty at least.”

The two looked over at him as he nodded up the mountainside at the golden leafed trees. In the late afternoon light, the white trunks seemed to stand out in the knife sharp air of the mountains and for a moment, they were all quiet.

“It’s a view at least,” Kyle said as he shut the bear box.

“That’s true,” Lonnie said and she smiled, making Kyle smile, which led to Rogelio smiling.

“You want me to cook tonight?” Rogelio asked.

“Naw, you’ve been running all day,” Lonnie said. “We’ve just been sitting around. You kick back, we’ll do it.”

“So how did it go?” Kyle asked as he opened the bear box back up.

Rogelio shrugged as he said, “Walked out to the entry booth and ran into someone who was going that way. They dropped me off in town at the parts store. Did my thing, got the groceries, and then found a ride back.”

Kyle and Lonnie both stopped and stared at Rogelio as they waited for him to go on. Finally Lonnie was the one to speak up as she said, “You’ve been gone all day. That’s it?”

Rogelio shrugged as he said, “Took me a bit to find someone coming this way.”

“How is it you can play a guitar for a twenty minute solo but you can’t tell a story?” Kyle said.

“Different skill sets,” Rogelio said.

“You’re killing me,” Lonnie said. “Nothing else happened.”

“Just talked with a few people, sat around at a park, and then found that guy coming out to do some off-roading and talked him into letting me tag a long,” Rogelio said. “Really, there’s nothing much to say about it.”

“Well go get your guitar,” Lonnie said. “Talk to us that way.”

Rogelio agreed as he went over and got the guitar out of the van. He sat back down and started playing as the wind got a little cooler as it flowed down the mountain as the Sun started to set. He started out with Redemption Song by Bob Marley and used that to segue into something of his own creation, slow and easy like the old song. Kyle went and got a small hand drum out of the back of the van as well and played along as Lonnie whistled and dumped food into the pot as she lit up some charcoal. For a moment, things were good. After a little bit, Lonnie brought the pot over to the table as she sat it down.

“Corn chowder… with rice,” Lonnie said. “We’ve been eating a lot of rice.”

“It’s filling,” Rogelio said as he sat the guitar on the bench next to him.

“I’m not going to complain,” Kyle said.

“Didn’t say you were,” Lonnie replied as she sat a few spoons on the table next to the pot. Kyle looked at her but kept his mouth shut as they began to eat. After finishing up and cleaning up, Kyle started to build a little campfire as the Sun slipped away and the stars started to come out.

“Did the ranger ever come by to collect the fee today?” Rogelio asked.

“Nope, never saw them,” Lonnie said.

“Let’s just pretend we’ve only been here one night,” Kyle said.

“Look at you, being all risk taker,” Lonnie said and Kyle blushed as the flame from his lighter quickly climbed up through the bone dry twigs he’d used for his fire.

“It’s just an idea,” Kyle said.

“And one I’m going with,” Lonnie said. “Bad enough being stuck here, I’d hate to be dead broke when we left.”

“Did you see any of the other campers?” Kyle said.

“I think there’s someone up by the entrance. Haven’t seen them though, just their tent. There might be a few people in the RV campground but that’s off that way,” Rogelio said with a gesture to the south and west.

“Do we really have a national park campground all to ourselves?” Lonnie said.

“Probably not, but it is pretty quiet isn’t it?” Rogelio replied.

“It is,” Kyle said.

“Well, I got something for us, since we’re stuck here,” Rogelio said as he reached into his baggy jacket and brought out a square bottle full of a clear liquid.

“Please tell me that’s not the kind you can strip paint with,” Lonnie said as she laughed.

“I have no idea,” Rogelio said. “It was the cheapest bottle of vodka they had in the largest size they had.”

“So yes, it is the kind that strips paint,” Lonnie said as Kyle came over.

“It wasn’t that bad,” he said as he took the bottle from Rogelio and broke the seal.

“Yes it was,” Lonnie said. “Why did you even drink that brand?”

“Because it was cheap and we were broke,” Rogelio said as Kyle took a swig, let out a thin stream of air from between his lips and then took another swig.

“Whoa, slow down there,” Lonnie said.

“No, I need this to tolerate your ass,” Kyle shot back as he took a third swig.

“Hey, that’s not called for,” Rogelio said.

“And I didn’t ask for your opinion on whether or not it was,” Kyle said. Rogelio reached out and took the bottle from Kyle, who didn’t fight him.

“You two good?” Rogelio said as he took a swig.

“Just been snipping at me today is all,” Lonnie said.

“I’ve been snipping at *you?”* Kyle replied. “Are you fucking kidding me?”

“Here it goes again,” Lonnie said as she rolled her eyes.

“Oh, I’m the unreasonable one. I’ve been trying to get along with my ex-boyfriend and my ex-bandmate all this time but you’ve been chewing on my ass the whole time,” Kyle said and as Rogelio started to speak up Kyle shook his head and swiped his arm as he said, “And don’t you say anything either as you’ve just chosen to stay quiet most of the time.”

“What the fuck?” Lonnie said. “You just took the sips, there’s no way you’re going to say you’re drunk. You’re just being an asshole right now.”

“I am!?” Kyle said. “Are you really trying that bullshit right now? You’ve been an ass almost this whole trip!”

“Guys, calm down,” Rogelio said. “We just need to chill.”

“Yeah, what a shock, Rogelio says to chill,” Kyle said as he put his hands up as if shocked. “You ever think that’s why we didn’t do so well?”

“What do you mean? I thought we’d just decided it was better apart,” Rogelio said.

“No! You decided that!” Kyle said.

“You’re the one who decided that,” Lonnie said. “I remember that fight.”

“It wasn’t even a fight!” Kyle said. “And yeah, I did, but that was to see if he’d show any emotion beyond ‘chill’ and he didn’t! You didn’t even fucking care!”

“That’s not cool, of course I cared,” Rogelio said. “I was just trying to do what you wanted.”

“You always did! You never tried to do something for yourself! Even when we were still at camp you didn’t seem to really worry about anything or care! We were fucking in a tent and could have been caught and had all kinds of awful shit happen but you didn’t care!” Kyle said.

“What the fuck is this all about?” Lonnie said.

Rogelio just shrugged and Kyle yanked the bottle out of his hand, took another swig, this one deeper than the last three, and then shoved the bottle back at Rogelio as he said, “I’m fucking walking out of here.”

Kyle stomped off into the dark as Lonnie looked on in surprise and Rogelio just sighed.

“What did you do to him today?” Rogelio said.

“I didn’t do anything!” Lonnie said. “We’ve just bickered a little! Aren’t you going to go and stop him?”

“It’s twenty miles to the highway,” Rogelio said with a shake of his head. “There’s no way he’s walking that far tonight. He’s just gotta walk his anger off.”

“Damn, that’s kind of cold,” Lonnie said. “Do you really not care?”

“Of course I care,” Rogelio said. “I just… I don’t know, I don’t want it to be a big thing.”

“Dude, he just told you your relationship ended because of this,” Lonnie said.

“What do you care? You were happy about it ending,” Rogelio said.

Lonnie looked away as she said, “I didn’t say I was happy.”

“Yeah, you did,” Rogelio said. “You and I got shitfaced and you said you were glad it was over.”

“I did not,” Lonnie said. “I just said I was glad it was over because you two were making each other miserable.”

“I’ve known you for years,” Rogelio said. “You know I can tell when you’re full of shit.”

Lonnie took the bottle from Rogelio as she said, “Shut up.”

“Great come back,” Rogelio said.

“Just shut up,” Lonnie said as she took a swig of the vodka and then proceeded to cough and wheeze. “What the fuck man!? That’s worse than that shit Kyle used to drink!”

“It’s not that bad,” Rogelio said as he took the bottle and took a sip.

“I could use that to start a fire!” Lonnie said.

“Now you’re being melodramatic,” Rogelio said. “It’s only eighty proof. There’s more water than alcohol in this and you’re changing the subject.”

“No, I’m not, there’s no subject to change,” Lonnie said.

“Have you been mean to Kyle today?” Rogelio said.

“Why would you care? You two broke up, remember?” Lonnie said.

“Doesn’t mean I don’t still care about him,” Rogelio mumbled as he took out his cigarettes.

Lonnie watched him as he took one out and lit it, not looking at her the whole time.

“You’re fucking kidding me,” she said. Rogelio took a drag and let out a long stream of smoke through his nose. “You still love him don’t you!?”

“Shut up,” Rogelio said as he reached out for the bottle.

“Nope, not letting you,” Lonnie said as she held the bottle out of reach. “You better tell me.”

Rogelio looked away at the fire light flickering off the scrubby pines behind the campsite.

“Dude, are you really going to pull your silent and stoic bullshit now?” Lonnie said. “You told me you were cool and over it and all that.”

Rogelio took another puff and refused to meet her eyes as she got up and started to circle around in front of him.

"Give me one," Lonnie said. Rogelio held the cigarette pack out to her and she took it from him as she extracted two. She stuck one behind her ear, put the other in her mouth, lit it up, and held the pack out to him. "OK, so we know you can hear me so you better answer me."

Rogelio responded by rolling his eyes and taking the pack back.

"Dude, why?" Lonnie said. "I mean, you two were cute but it's not like you were good together after that honeymoon period. You needed someone else, someone who'd make you happy."

"It wasn't that bad," Rogelio said. "We were happy."

"So you do know how to speak," Lonnie said. "And that's not how I remember it."

"Because you always saw the worst in him," Rogelio said.

"I did not," Lonnie said. "I'm just looking out for my buddy."

“Yeah, you did,” Rogelio said. “I swear, he couldn’t do anything without you taking it in the worst light.”

“You’re really going to defend him? After what he did?” Lonnie said.

Rogelio rolled his eyes as he said, “I told you, he didn’t cheat on me. That was you seeing way too much into something. He’s a friendly dude.”

“Listen, how well do you really know him?” Lonnie said.

“I know him just fine,” Rogelio said.

“No, you don’t,” Lonnie said and then held her hand up. “No, hear me out. You’ve known him at camp, yeah, but that was a thing where you both were trying to hide who you were. Then you went from that to living together and being in a band and you all never really talked because you never really talk and then it all fell apart. I think I'm the only one who really knows you, like the inner you, and that’s because I’ve known you forever.”

“He knows me just fine,” Rogelio said. “And I knew him just fine and I still say you always took whatever he did in the wrong way.”

“Because you deserved something else,” Lonnie said. “Something better.”

Rogelio took a drink from the bottle as he shook his head.

“Why don’t you like him?”

“I just told you,” Lonnie said.

“No, you said we didn’t know each other. Why don’t you like him?” Rogelio replied.

“He’s not any good for you. You need someone that’ll motivate you,” Lonnie said.

“Ah, this again,” Rogelio said with a grunt.

Lonnie took a drag off her cigarette before saying, “Yes, this again. Come on, you’ve got this great talent with the guitar. You could do so much more.”

“I do exactly as much as I want to,” Rogelio said. “Why are you always driving me?”

“Because you could do so much more! I just said it! I don’t know why you’re so blase! It’s like today! You just kind of strolled in, said, ‘Whelp, stuck here, oh well’ and then sat down! Nothing gets you going!” Lonnie said.

“Why do you care so much now?” Rogelio said as he took a puff on his cigarette before stubbing it out and flicking it towards the fire pit and missing.

Lonnie walked over and picked up the butt and threw it in the fire as she said, “Because, I’ve always cared but it’s killing me seeing you just sit around and do nothing.”

“What have you done?” Rogelio said. “You just sit around and don’t do shit.”

“I’m going to school, asshole!” Lonnie said.

Rogelio pulled his head back in surprise as he said, “Since when!?”

“I’m in my second semester,” Lonnie said.

“You never told me,” Rogelio said. “What for?”

“I don’t fucking know,” Lonnie said. “It seemed the right thing to do.”

“I mean, what are you going for?” Rogelio said.

“I don’t know that either,” Lonnie said. “I’m just getting the basics done.”

“Still, that’s cool, why didn’t you tell me? I would have gone with you,” Rogelio said.

“Because of that,” Lonnie said. “Because I wanted you to do something for yourself. I wanted you to have some drive. I wanted you to have some ambition.”

“That’s never been me and you know it,” Rogelio said. “I’m just happy scooting along. I got a place to stay, I got my guitar, and why shouldn’t I be happy?”

Lonnie stalked over and snatched the bottle out of his hand as she took a hard pull off it and then slapped it back into his hand.

“You just don’t fucking get it, do you?” she said before stalking off into the night, lighting her other cigarette as she went.

Chapter End Notes

This is so much fun. :) I've got nothing much else to say on this one for now.

The Third Night

Chapter Summary

> It's rolling into the third night of Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio at the campground and things are starting to fray. Will the center hold or will it turn into a raging storm?

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After Lonnie had stalked off the night before, Rogelio had sat on the table for a little while longer, watching the coals flicker in the fire. He'd finally got up and put the tarp back up as best he could in the dark and put everyone's blanket rolls under it. The air was cold enough that he could see his breath in the light of the small flashlight he used so when he'd rolled himself up into his blankets he kept his clothes on. He'd always been cold blooded and the high mountain air at night in October wasn't doing him any favors.

Kyle was the first to come back, quietly slipping under the tarp and rolling up in his blankets. Lonnie came back shortly after Kyle and Rogelio could see her sitting on the bench smoking in the faint light of the moon as it skipped in and out of clouds. She finally came over and slid under the tarp as Rogelio pretended to be asleep. He fell asleep not long after and so missed the first snowflakes falling.

Rogelio woke up to the sounds of Lonnie cursing softly under her breath. When he opened his eyes, he first wondered why the tarp looked so much closer to him than it had been the night before

and then suddenly realized it was sagging down under the weight of the snow on top of it.

"What happened?" Rogelio asked and Lonnie looked at him like he was an idiot.

"What do you think happened? It snowed," Lonnie said. "And now we're going to be fucking stuck out here."

"Why? It doesn't look that bad," Rogelio said as he rolled over and looked out. He had to admit, it didn't look great but it couldn't have been more than four or five inches and he'd managed that back home. Although, he also knew that kind of snowfall back home would cause no end of havoc but they were in Colorado and he figured the local government would be able to deal with the snowfall a bit better.

"No, it doesn't, but the belt for the car isn't here now is it?" Lonnie said, her voice cutting through his thoughts. "And maybe it gets delayed by this and maybe this crap doesn't melt away in time before the next storm hits and this gets even worse."

"I'm sure it'll be fine," Rogelio said.

Lonnie huffed and pulled her blankets up around her shoulders a little tighter but didn't say anything else. Rogelio noticed that Kyle wasn't under the tarp but then heard the sounds of someone walking through the snow and then saw Kyle come up and crawl

under the tarp, being careful to knock off any snow before he did. He crawled under his blankets as he said, “The bathroom is nice and warm if you’re chilly.”

Rogelio wasn’t sure what to say. Kyle had stomped off in anger the night before but now he was acting like nothing was wrong. It’d been the same when they’d dated. They’d fight and then Kyle would act like it was all fine, even when it wasn’t, and Rogelio would let him. He thought about asking him now how he felt but chickened out.

“Well, at least we have a place to stay,” Lonnie said, her voice thick with sarcasm. “Nice and fancy.”

Kyle’s mouth tightened into a thin line but he didn’t say anything as he pulled the blankets tight around himself. They all sat like that as the world got brighter. It was a directionless light coming through the cloud cover that the mountains disappeared into. There was very little wind and everything seemed hush, like the world had gone to sleep for a little bit and so that’s what the three did, sleep through the morning hours. Around lunchtime, they all seemed to come to an agreement and got up and tried to go for a hike but didn’t have much luck. They got as far as the edge of the dunes, not too far from their camp, and crouched down in the lee of a pinion pine bush looking out over the sand towards the dunes. They could hear a car somewhere in the park, its engine loud in the quiet.

“Wonder who’s out of their mind enough to be out in this?” Lonnie said as she lit up a cigarette.

“Other than us?” Rogelio commented.

“Obviously,” Lonnie said with a snort.

Rogelio just shrugged. Kyle was looking out at the sand dunes. Part of them were covered in snow but the crest of the dunes seemed to be clear where wind had kept the snow from sticking.

“I wish we had more time here,” Kyle said.

“God, why?” Lonnie replied.

“I mean, not like we are now, kind of eeking along, but with like, enough time to walk out there,” Kyle responded, nodding out into the dune field.

“It would be pretty cool,” Rogelio said.

“It would, wouldn’t it?” Kyle said absently. “Just kind of be nothing but sand and sky.”

Rogelio and Lonnie both looked at Kyle as he stared out into the dunes. After a moment, Lonnie said, “Dude, do we have to worry you’re going to follow an unheard voice out into nothingness?”

Kyle looked at her for a moment and then laughed as he shook his head.

"Naw, I just, I don't know, I just like the idea. Just simple, you know?"

Lonnie nodded as she said, "Yeah, I get you."

Kyle's eyes got a little bigger as he realized what she said before he smiled at her.

"Want to go out there now?" Kyle said.

Lonnie shook her head as she said, "Sure, let's just go out there when none of us are really dressed for the weather. We're wearing hoodies and a few layers of t-shirts for Christ sake. I'm sure nothing will go wrong."

Rogelio snorted as he said, "I mean, we're already running around out here as it is."

"That's true," Kyle said. "You're right though. Probably not a good idea."

“I mean, maybe not, but maybe we should anyway,” Lonnie said.

“What?” Rogelio said. “You were just against it.”

“Yeah, but what else are we going to do today?” Lonnie said.

“Not get lost in a trackless dune field,” Rogelio said.

“You walk in a straight line, how hard can it be?” Lonnie said.

“OK, yeah, I know it was my idea but I’m going to veto my idea,” Kyle said.

“Come on, just out to the edge of the first dunes,” Lonnie said, gesturing at the sand in front of her. “We won’t go out of sight of here.”

It was quiet for a moment followed by Rogelio sighing.

“Fine.”

Thirty minutes later found them trudging through the snow and sand, still headed for the first big line of dunes.

“I’d like to say that I did say it wasn’t a good idea,” Kyle said as he slid a little as the sand under the snow shifted a bit.

“Yeah, yeah, duly noted but I think we’re almost there. Maybe. How cold you think it is? Lonnie said as she pulled her hood a little tighter as the wind kicked up a little.

“Below freezing,” Rogelio said.

“Doesn’t really feel it,” Kyle said.

“It doesn’t feel below freezing to you?” Lonnie said. “You alright?”

“I mean, it doesn’t have that damp edge, like back home,” Kyle said. “You know? It feels dry or something.”

“Yeah, I can see that,” Rogelio replied. “Still cold as hell though.”

They walked a few more feet and they all stopped as a blast of frigid wind hit them. For a moment, it seemed like they were in a snow globe of nothing but the three of them and swirling snow, ice, and sand. Lonnie saw snowflakes starting up and when the wind died down a bit, she said, “It’s starting to snow again.”

Rogelio and Kyle both looked up and saw the flakes swirling in.

"Maybe it's just junk getting blown off the dunes?" Rogelio said, his face trying to be hopeful even as his voice said he knew better.

"Should we head back?" Kyle said, as he tried to pull himself into his hoodie and t-shirts a little more.

"I think we'd be idiots not to," Lonnie said.

"I think we're idiots for being out here already," Rogelio said.

When the three turned around to leave, they didn't take a step. The mountains had disappeared behind a blowing curtain of snow. They all looked down to see their tracks disappearing rapidly as the wind picked up.

"So this is how I die, huh?" Lonnie said with a snort.

"That's not funny," Kyle said, trying to control his teeth as they began to chatter a little. "We just turned around, we can see where we came from so let's just start walking back. It's not that hard."

“We’re going to get lost,” Rogelio said. “If we just start walking without a reference, we’re going to get lost.”

“If we don’t start walking, we’re going to fucking freeze to death out here,” Lonnie said. “So how about we make a decision and do it?”

Rogelio shook his head as he said, “OK, I’ve got an idea; we’re going to do this methodical. We turned around, we should be facing roughly the right direction like Kyle said. I can still sort of see our last footprints. I’m going to walk forward and one of you come with me. We’ll make sure we can still see whoever is left and then when we get to the place where we can just see the last person, one of us will stop and the last person will walk up. The other person will keep going and stop when they can just see the middle person. It’ll be like leapfrog and we should be able to stay in a straight line as long as the front person keeps the other two lined up behind them. You get it?”

“Yeah, I think so,” Lonnie said.

Kyle didn’t say anything, just nodded as he shivered.

“I’m going,” Rogelio said, “Who’s going with me?”

“Take Kyle,” Lonnie said. “I’ll hang back.”

“You sure?” Kyle managed to say. “I don’t want to leave you.”

“Hey! We’re wasting time! Go!” Lonnie said.

Rogelio nodded and started walking as the last of their old footprints got blown away. The next hour was slow and laborious. A few times, Rogelio was sure they were screwed but he just took a deep breath and kept going. Once, the heavy snow and wind cleared just enough that he got a glimpse of the mountains and he was pretty sure he recognized them enough to say they were going the right way. Kyle had stopped talking and was just shivering and Rogelio wasn’t doing much better himself. Lonnie kept them both moving whenever she passed them though, giving them little pep talks as they went, a hand on the shoulder sometimes, a little laugh at others, even as her teeth started to chatter in the blowing wind.

It was only an hour but it seemed much longer in the frozen almost featureless hell they found themselves in and when Rogelio first spotted some of the pinion pines along the edge of the dunes, he was sure he was imagining it but as he walked a little closer, it got easier to see. He stopped and waved his shaking hands furiously to get the others attention and to get them to come up to him. Not long after, they found themselves back at their campsite. The tarp was standing, sort of, half of it bowed under with snow, and Lonnie sent Rogelio and Kyle under it as she worked to get it clear of snow before joining them both.

“I think Kyle has hypothermia,” Rogelio said as soon as Lonnie got under.

"I… Issa… I'm fine," Kyle managed to say as he shivered so hard, they were sure he was going to fall over.

"No, you're not," Lonnie said to Kyle before turning to Rogelio. "I think it's time to abandon tarp and get to the bathrooms. Go, I'll get the blankets."

"Come on," Rogelio said, scooting out of the shelter and back into the wind as he beckoned at Kyle. He couldn't feel his fingers at this point and wasn't sure he wanted to look at them as he got Kyle out and over to the bathrooms. He hustled Kyle into the small restrooms and got Kyle seated on a small bench by the lone shower in the room. The room wasn't hot by any stretch of the imagination, it couldn't have been more than fifty-five degrees, but after the cold outside it felt almost sweltering.

Rogelio rubbed Kyle's hands and arms, and saw that his own hands didn't seem to be seriously frostbitten even though he was still worried about his face, as he tried to talk to Kyle. It was rambling and didn't even make sense to Rogelio but he figured anything was good to keep Kyle's attention.

"You're too good to me," Kyle said, his voice slow as if he was drunk.

"I'm just trying to keep you from freezing to death," Rogelio said as he sat down next to him and pulled him close.

Kyle gave a little smile as Rogelio did and said, “Yeah, I’m alright.”

Lonnie finally came in and dropped the blankets on the bench, as well as a few odds and ends she’d grabbed from around the camp, and shook the snow out of her hair as she said, “We have another problem.”

“What?” Rogelio said as he wrapped Kyle up in a few blankets.

“We’ve been cooking over a fire,” Lonnie said. “How in the hell are we going to cook anything?”

“Pretty much everything is canned,” Rogelio said. “We can eat it cold.”

“Can we eat it frozen?” Lonnie said.

Rogelio looked at her before he slowly said, “Shit.”

“Yeah,” Lonnie said as she took a deep breath. “I’m going to go get the food.”

Rogelio got up, to Kyle muttering a little as he burrowed a little deeper into his blanket and trying to lean against Rogelio, and

said, “No. Stay here and warm up a little. I can do that.”

Rogelio didn’t want to go out. The wind was howling around the building and when he opened the bathroom door, he realized it was a full fledged blizzard with white out conditions going on. He thought for a moment of going back in but he could still see the campsite, barely, and so he quickly walked over to the bear box and unloaded their food and then staggered back to the bathroom. At one point, a gust of wind threw up a curtain of snow and he felt his heart drop as it obscured everything around him to just a few feet of visibility but he waited, even as he felt his fingers and face screaming from the cold, and it cleared enough for him to see where he needed to go.

He staggered back in to Lonnie sitting beside Kyle with arm around him as he curled into her side, looking off at nothing. Rogelio put the food in a sink and sat down on the floor next to her, handing her the bottle of vodka he’d grabbed out of the bear box.

“Think that’s a good idea?” she said.

“No,” Rogelio said, but he didn’t pull the bottle back.

Lonnie took the bottle and unscrewed the top but didn’t take a drink. The only sound in the room was the howl of the wind and the faint hum of the overhead fluorescents. Rogelio waited for her and found himself slipping into sleep in the warmth of the room. He woke up several hours later, to an almost pitch black room. He

could feel someone leaned against him and realized it was Lonnie.

"You awake?" Lonnie whispered.

"Yeah," Rogelio whispered back. "Why are the lights out?"

And then he realized that it felt cooler than it had been.

"Power went out," Lonnie said.

"When? What time is it?"

"Don't know, a while ago, and it's a little after sundown. Doesn't sound like it's letting up out there either."

Rogelio heard the howling wind and thought about something he'd heard once about polar explorers talking about how they sometimes thought they'd heard voices in the wind. He could see what they meant and it caused the hair on the back of his neck to stand up.

"What now?" Rogelio said.

Lonnie put an arm around Rogelio and gave him a hug before she said something.

"I didn't have this on my plan for how I was going to die."

Unlike earlier out by the dunes, Lonnie wasn't joking but the way she said it was so matter of fact that it took Rogelio a moment to register fully what she had said. When it did register he looked at her, or the vague shape of her in the darkness, as he said, "Come on, it's not that bad."

"I've been sitting here since the lights went out, thinking," Lonnie said. "These storms can last for days. We're pretty high up in the mountains, all things considered. We're miles from the nearest highway and we only have a little bit of food and we damn near froze to death in a short hike before this turned into a blizzard. We're fucked."

"Is it really that bad?" Kyle's voice said from the darkness, at least sounding way better than it had earlier.

"No, it's not," Rogelio said.

"Yeah, it is," Lonnie said. "Don't bullshit him. We're hunkered down in a fucking toilet with almost no food and the wrong clothes for this. I mean, the part is supposed to be here tomorrow but you really think that guy is even going to try and get out here, assuming this has passed by then?"

“Come on, we’ve got the blankets and yeah, it’s going to suck if we have to ration out the food but this isn’t going to last forever,” Rogelio said. “Water isn’t going to be a problem, we got plenty outside we can melt.”

“How?” Lonnie said.

“Still got that vodka,” Rogelio said. “Or I got some starter fluid in the car or I can even try and siphon some gas out of the tank.”

“We could just build a fire in here,” Kyle said, his voice sounding a bit more optimistic. “It’s a concrete building.”

“With wooden stalls and roof,” Lonnie said with a snort.

“OK, so we’d have to be careful,” Kyle said.

“Listen, I’m with you,” Rogelio said. “I didn’t plan on dying here and I refuse to do so.”

“Oh, you refuse to die,” Lonnie said and Rogelio could swear he heard the smile on her face.

“Yeah,” Rogelio said. “We’re going to come out of this, I know it.”

Everyone was quiet for a moment and the howling wind didn’t seem so bad.

“I’m going to open up a can of something,” Kyle said. “I’m starving.”

There was a click and suddenly the room was bathed in the cold light of the little lantern.

“Where did that come from?” Rogelio said. “I thought it was still out in the tarp.”

“I dragged it in with the blankets along with a few of our water bottles,” Lonnie said. “Forgot about it.”

“Well, it’s been digging into my ribs,” Kyle said as he got up, pulling the blanket around him like a shawl. He set the lantern on the bench and walked over to the sink and rummaged around in the bag. “I think we can eat one of these cans tonight and be alright. I think the water bottles might be a little thawed by now too. If we want a little heat, we can stuff the empty can full of toilet paper, douse it with something flammable, and then set it on fire.”

“Wait, what?” Lonnie said. “That sounds fucking ridiculous.”

“It’s how we did it at camp for little torches on the ground,” Kyle said and turned to Rogelio. “Remember?”

“Yeah, and we only did it once because some kid burned themselves,” Rogelio said.

“Well, it still worked,” Kyle said. “We’re not idiot kids anymore.”

Lonnie looked around the bathroom they were sitting in as the wind howled outside and snorted as she said, “Well, let’s say we’re not kids anymore.”

“Let’s hold off,” Rogelio said. “It’s not that cold.”

“Yet,” Lonnie muttered.

“You’re a ray of sunshine,” Kyle said with a laugh as he cracked the can open and sniffed at it. “Beef and vegetable soup. Nice.”

Kyle took a spoon and took out a mouthful and took a bite. He grimaced a little as he ate.

“Yeah, that’s the face of fine dining right there,” Lonnie said.

Kyle came over and sat down next to them.

"It's not that bad," he said as he handed it to Lonnie.

"Yeah, that's a ringing endorsement," Lonnie replied as she took the can from him and took her own bite. "OK, that's… yeah, I don't know what that mouth feel is but it is not one I want to remember."

Rogelio took the can from her as he said, "It's food." He took a bite and then got a bit of a contemplative look on his face. "That's not half bad."

"You have the worst taste," Kyle said as he took the can from him.

"That's the fucking truth," Lonnie said and then looked away.

"What was that supposed to mean?" Kyle said, looking hurt.

"Nothing. You're just trying to read into it," Lonnie said.

"Come on, this isn't the place," Rogelio said.

Lonnie didn’t say anything but took the can from Kyle. They were quiet while they ate the rest of the cold soup. Lonnie pulled out the vodka bottle and took a swig before passing it over to Rogelio. The bottle made a couple of circuits around the circle in silence before Lonnie took out a cigarette and lit it up. Rogelio got one from her and lit up himself.

“This just got worse,” Lonnie said as she looked at her pack. “Only a couple left. Damn, maybe I’d rather freeze to death after all.”

Rogelio snorted as he said, “That’s not funny.”

Kyle was fiddling with the empty can and had got up and shoved wads of toilet paper into it.

“You sure that’s a good idea?” Rogelio said as Kyle dumped some vodka into the can.

“It’s fine,” Kyle said and then lit the paper. It burned yellow and smokey but it did burn and all three of them leaned into the heat. After less than a minute, Kyle set the lid over it and snuffed out the flame.

“Hey!” Lonnie said. “That was actually warm!”

“I figured I’d save it for when we go to sleep,” Kyle said. “Warm it up a little in here.”

Lonnie shrugged as she said, “Well, we should probably just go to sleep now. It’s not like we got a lot to do until morning.”

“Yeah, I’m with her,” Rogelio said. “Light it up.”

Kyle nodded and lit it again. The fire flickered and little bits of glowing ash from the toilet paper floated up. Lonnie reached over and turned out the lamp and everyone pulled their blankets around themselves and huddled towards the little flame.

After a few minutes, Kyle looked up at Lonnie and said, “Why do you hate me?”

“What?” Lonnie said.

“You heard me,” Kyle said.

“Hey, this isn’t the place for this,” Rogelio said.

“No, it’s the perfect place for this,” Kyle said. “None of us can storm off and I’m tired of dancing around it and just drunk enough to ask so I want to know.”

“I don’t hate you,” Lonnie said.

“You sure seem to,” Kyle said. “You can’t go five seconds it seems like without insulting me or making some crack about me.”

“That’s just me,” Lonnie said.

“Did I do something to you? That wasn’t you when I first met you, we got along,” Kyle said.

“Sure I was like that, you just didn’t notice,” Lonnie said.

“It actually isn’t,” Rogelio said. “You don’t do that to me.”

“Sure I do,” Lonnie said.

Rogelio was shaking his head as he said, “No, you don’t, not like you do to him.”

“Oh, so it’s gang up on Lonnie time now?” Lonnie said. “Got me fucking trapped in a shitty bathroom in a blizzard so it’s time to come at me?”

“I just want to know what I did to you,” Kyle said. “Seriously, I don’t treat you like that. I like you when you’re not being mean to me.”

“And we’re not ganging up on you,” Rogelio said.

“Yes, you are,” Lonnie said and snatched the vodka bottle from Kyle before taking a drink.

“Is that a good idea?” Rogelio asked.

“Fuck you and your good idea,” Lonnie said before taking another drink.

Rogelio took the bottle from her at that point as he said, “I’m not ganging up on you, I’m just saying you don’t seem to like Kyle. You haven’t for a long time.”

“Yeah,” Kyle said as Rogelio looked at the bottle and then sighed and took a drink.

“Listen, I just… you rub me the wrong way sometimes,” Lonnie said. “Fucking let it go, alright?”

Kyle took the bottle from Rogelio and took a long drink before he shook his head and said, "No, I'm not letting it go. I always liked you and I tried to be friendly but just the longer it went on, the more you seemed to hate me and frankly, I'm sick of it and I'm not going to let it go until you give me a better answer than that I rub you the wrong way bullshit. Is it because I was with Rogelio? Is that it?"

Lonnie took the bottle from him and took a drink before she said, "What are you trying to say? I don't have a thing for him, I just think… you know, he's one of my oldest friends and frankly, you were terrible for him."

"No, I wasn't!" Kyle said as Rogelio took the bottle. "You were always around and riding me about being a shit boyfriend and maybe I was towards the end but it didn't start that way!"

"I mean, we did fight a lot," Rogelio said. "We broke up for a reason."

"Yeah! Because you were always so mellow!" Kyle said. "I didn't want to break up! You hear me!? I didn't want to fucking break up!"

"Oh God, are you about to tell him some bullshit like you still love him?" Lonnie said with a laugh.

"Fuck you, Lonnie!" Kyle said.

“Great come back,” Lonnie said as she waved a little smoke out of her face. “What other…”

“No, fuck you! I’m not taking your bullshit anymore!” Kyle said, cutting her off. “I swear, it’s like you're a jealous ex half the time the way you acted with us!”

“Guys, chill, alright?” Rogelio said but Lonnie was already shouting over him.

“Oh, don’t give me the chill bullshit, Rogelio, and what do you mean jealous ex!? That makes no sense!” Lonnie said as she got to her feet.

Kyle was on his feet as well as he said, “Yeah! Yeah, that’s it! You acted like you wanted him back or something but you never had him!”

“Fuck you!” Lonnie said.

“You know what!? That’s enough!” Rogelio roared as he stood up and pointed. “You know what!? Yeah, Kyle, I still love you! I hate that we fought and I hate that we broke up and I was so hoping something would change on this trip and maybe it’d be different but it’s not but I’m going to say it! I love you!”

The room went silent as Kyle looked at Rogelio in shock and Lonnie looked away as she tried not to cry.

"Lonnie, that doesn't mean I don't want to be your friend or anything you know," Rogelio said quietly. "I just… I couldn't not say it anymore."

"You still love me?" Kyle said just as quietly as Rogelio nodded at him.

Lonnie looked back with tears streaming down her face as she yelled, "Well, God damnit, I love you too, you fucking idiot!"

It was Rogelio's turn to look shocked as he said, "But… wait… what!?"

"I've loved you for years! Why the fuck did you think I drove hours in the middle of the night to come pick you and him up from camp!? Why do you think I was always hanging around!? Yeah, I'm your friend but I wanted so much more and God fucking damnit I had to wait to tell you this until after you fucking decided to bare your soul to him and it had to be in this shitty place!"

"Lon, it's not… I… I mean, I love you too… I just… fuck," Rogelio said as he tried to find words and utterly failed.

Kyle opened his mouth to speak and then stopped as he heard a crackling noise, like a spark from a piece of burning toilet paper had landed on an old wood rafter that was dry as a bone from being at high altitude inside of a bathroom where it never got wet and was in low humidity a lot of the time and because of all that had decided to take that spark and start merrily burning. He looked up to see flames licking up from one of the beams and starting to work on the roof and the other beams around it.

"Get some water!" Kyle screamed as he pointed at the roof.

The other two looked at him like he'd grown an extra head for a moment before they figured out what he was saying. All three of them bolted for the sinks and turned on the taps. Nothing happened for a moment and then the sound of banging came from the wall and then water started seeping out from the baseboards while only a trickle came out of one faucet before coming to a stop.

"Are you fucking serious!?" Lonnie shouted as she grabbed Kyle and started dragging him towards the door as the room filled with smoke as flames blossomed overhead. Kyle managed to keep his feet as he wrenched open the door to a sudden heavy gust of air rushing through the door. The fire, that could be best described up to that point as worrying, took the new inrush of oxygen from the door and ramped up to a roar. Lonnie shoved Kyle out the door and turned around to go after Rogelio when he was suddenly right at the door, pushing a load of blankets into her arms.

"Go!" Rogelio shouted and Lonnie turned around and ran out into the raging storm after Kyle. When she turned around, she realized that Rogelio hadn't followed her and was about to drop the

blankets and run in after him when he came stumbling out of the door, another bundle of blankets in his arm as he coughed and hacked as he made his way over to them.

"You went back in!?" Kyle shouted over the wind as Rogelio got up to them.

Rogelio was coughing and hacking as he wiped at the tears streaming from his eyes from smoke but nodded and shoved the blankets at Kyle.

"Had to… get… these…"

Lonnie was wrapping one of the blankets around her head and shoulders as she said, "Well, we're well and truly fucked now!"

Kyle stood there with blankets in his arms as he watched part of the roof collapse in a shower of sparks only to be followed by flames shooting into the sky from the rest of the roof and he began to laugh. It wasn't much of a humorous laugh, though there was some of that in there, it was more of hysterical laugh, a laugh of someone who knew that they might not live to see the next sunrise but God damn did they find the whole situation just unbearably absurd and thus, hysterical.

"What's so fucking funny!?" Rogelio shouted.

“Us!” Kyle shouted back over the wind. “This! Fuck it! If I die, I’m going to die with the truth out there! Lonnie, I’m pretty sure I love you too!”

Lonnie looked at Kyle as her face went through a dozen emotions that settled on her joining him in his laughter. Rogelio did the same a few seconds later and that’s how the park rangers found them a few minutes later, laughing like loons in front of a burning bathroom in a blizzard, as they pulled up in a Sno-Cat.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the long delay on this one! You might have already read on another of my fics that I had some shoulder issues that made it difficult to type. I'm still dealing with them but they're slowly starting to resolve so I'm able to type some more and so I finally got onto this one! This chapter ended up being way longer than I expected but I knew I wanted this to happen on this night and so I set it rolling. I've always loved this throuple but I really do after writing these three and their problems. I also think that the last few paragraphs are some of my favorite that I've written.

There's still one more chapter to go, an epilogue, and hopefully it won't take another month to get written this time. Thank you as always for reading!

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

It's all over, except for the confusion.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Well, I guess the argument for updating the bathroom just became moot,” one of the two rangers had said to the other ranger after they’d got Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle into the Sno-Cat.

The other ranger had just rolled her eyes as she turned around in the narrow front seat to see the other three packed into the back. They could just see her name tag velcroed to her heavy coat that said, “Begay.”

“I’m guessing you own that minivan?” she’d said, giving a little head nod towards the snow covered vehicle.

The three hadn’t known how to respond but Kyle had finally spoken.

“Yeah, that’s us.”

“Been trying to find you for a couple of days to get your camp fee; you kept not being around camp though,” Begay said.

“And then we decided to come out,” the other ranger said with a grin on her face. Her name tag said Werner on it. “Figured you might not be quite equipped to handle the weather but I see you had a nice fire going to keep yourselves warm.”

Begay did her best to keep a straight face and then completely gave a little head shake and chuckle.

“Are we in trouble, ma’am?” Kyle asked.

“I mean, you should be. I’m pretty sure I could find plenty to charge you on but we’re going to play it like this instead,” Begay said. “This isn’t going to do anything but burn down a bathroom that needed fixing up anyway and with the storm it’s not going to spread, so you’re going to go back to headquarters where there’s some nice comfy cots in a nice comfy storage room that you can bunk down in. Come morning, if the storm’s done, we’re going to get your little van out of there and you’re going to pay the fees you owe for your camping trip. Then you’re going to go home.”

“Begay, you do have a heart,” Werner said while blinking her eyes at her in a cutesy look that was marred by the laugh she gave a moment later.

“Just write the report like I tell you,” Begay said with a long suffering sigh as Werner gave a little sarcastic salute.

“Thank you,” the three in the back said quietly as Begay turned around and started the Sno-Cat forward. Werner gave the three of them a little wink before she turned around and pulled down a radio mike and called in a few details of where they were and where they were going.

Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie were all asleep, lulled to comfort by the warmth of the heater in the Sno-Cat’s cab, when the rangers pulled into headquarters. They got woken up by Begay who walked them to the storage room, showed them the bathrooms and cots, and then left them alone. Sprawled out on the cots, their blankets still smelling of smoke, the three stared at the ceiling of the storage room. A little light from the hallway outside came in around the door and each of them kept casting glances at each other, not sure who would speak up first but the stress and fear and just late hour weighed the words down in their throats and the three slowly slipped into sleep together.

The next morning came entirely too soon when someone pounded on the door of the storage room, shaking them all awake, as a

voice hollered for them to come on out to get some breakfast. There was tension between the three of them, awkward but strangely not uncomfortable, like the anticipation before a long planned trip that had seemed unlikely from its inception and now loomed. They spoke a few generic words to each other as they got untangled from blankets and straightened slept in clothes and used the bathroom before heading up the hall to a small break room and the smell of food.

"There's our little party," Werner said from where she stood by a small stove as she plated up some chilaquiles into old dented pie pans. "Hope you like this because it's the only thing we have for the moment." The three all squinted in the blinding light coming from the window and Werner looked over her shoulder at it for a moment before going on. "Yeah, it's only going to get worse. Clouds started clearing right before sunup and the Sun is starting to poke through. Hope you got sunglasses."

Rogelio said, "I do but they're in my car."

"No worries," Werner said as she motioned at them to sit at one of the battered round tables in the room as she carried over the food. "We can scare something up for you until then when we go out."

"You're being awful kind," Lonnie said as she pulled a plate over.

"Signed up to help people," Werner said as she sat down herself.

"We… um, we appreciate what you're doing," Rogelio said.

Werner just shrugged as she ate and Kyle didn't say anything as he began to eat like he was starving. Rogelio and Lonnie finally dug into their food and for a little bit, it was quiet in the room. Then Werner's radio squawked and they heard a voice calling for her. She answered briefly before standing up and shoveling the last of the food into her mouth.

"Gotta go but we'll be back in a bit to get you all on your way," Werner said as she washed her plate and silverware and then left

the room.

In the bright light of morning, the three friends looked at each with lowered heads as they tried to eat but without Werner there as a distraction, they couldn't really eat.

"Listen, it's weird, alright?" Rogelio said. "Can we just admit that it's weird?"

Lonnie shrugged as she said, "Fine, it's weird."

"It's not though," Kyle said as he pushed a little bit of egg around the plate. He looked up when he felt the other two looking at him. "OK, so maybe it is but come on, do you regret anything that was said last night?"

Lonnie and Rogelio looked at each other and then got tight, embarrassed smiles on their faces that matched the one that had just shown up on Kyle's face and the three gave an almost simultaneous nervous laugh that caused another when they realized what they'd done and then the three of them sighed in unison before laughing again at how they kept syncing up before they all quieted down. They sat silently for a minute or so before Rogelio suddenly stood up and took their plates and went over to the sink to start washing them. As he did, he started talking, facing the wall.

"OK, so, um, I don't really know what this means," Rogelio said. "I mean, where do we go from here?"

The room was silent again except for the sounds of a scrub pad on the plates. No one was looking at each other. Kyle stood up and walked over to the window, pushing the thin curtain aside to look out at the blinding light of the sun coming off the new fallen snow, almost making his eyes water from the intensity. There wasn't much to see out the window, it seemed to face a huge metal Quonset hut style building and he ran his finger along the windowsill, feeling the cold that'd seeped into it.

“How do you feel about me?” Kyle asked, quiet, not looking behind him.

After a pause, Rogelio said, “Uh, who are you asking?”

Kyle turned then, feeling a lifting feeling as he remembered the night before, standing in a blizzard in front of a burning building and feeling reckless and feeling that same feeling rising again.

“Fuck it, both of you,” Kyle said. “How do you feel about me? We laid it out last night because we were drunk and scared but what about now? How do we feel?”

“Oh, there’s a we now?” Lonnie said with a raised eyebrow.

“Don’t do that,” Kyle said. “Come on. I said how I feel already, I love both of you. How do you feel?”

A moment of quiet, Lonnie shuffled a little in her seat before Rogelio said, “I love you too, same as it was, world without end.”

Kyle grinned a little at the reference to an old prayer from camp that the two had learned as he said, “Amen.”

Lonnie was shaking her head as she said, “I don’t know how I feel about you. I mean, you love me?”

Kyle leaned back against the wall as he said, “Yeah, I guess I do. Is it friend love? Is it… you know, love love? I don’t know.”

“Thought you were gay,” Lonnie said.

“I think I’m just, you know, whatever,” Kyle replied. “Can we not go into that right now?”

“Fine,” Lonnie said as she sat back. “I mean… are we thinking…”

“Are we?” Rogelio said.

“Together?” Kyle said.

They stood, three points in the room, Rogelio at the sink, Lonnie at the table, Kyle at the window, and they looked at each other in the quiet and warmth.

Nightfall found them far from the mountains, driving across the high prairie as they crossed the state line towards home. Things had happened, they'd repaired the van, they'd settled things with Begay and Werner, and then they'd carefully driven away on the plowed road out of the park. Now, as they flew down the highway a light rain fell on the van, the remains of the blizzard blowing out as a rain shower at the lower altitude and the three of them held hands, shifting occasionally as the position that one or the other was in felt a bit uncomfortable. It was awkward, it was a bit uncomfortable, but it felt good, just like their newly formed relationship, and the three figured as they went on that they'd get both figured out together.

Chapter End Notes

> And it's done! I had a lot of fun with this one and getting the three together turned out to be a bit more of a juggle than I thought but I like how it all came out. I also realized, as I was editing, that the ranger Begay has a name that may seem a bit too on the nose but it's actually just a rather common Navajo surname and wasn't intentional at all. It comes from a Navajo word, biye', that means something like "his/her son" and was chosen by a lot of Navajo when the federal government forced them to get surnames. Anyway, thanks for reading and I hope you enjoyed it!

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